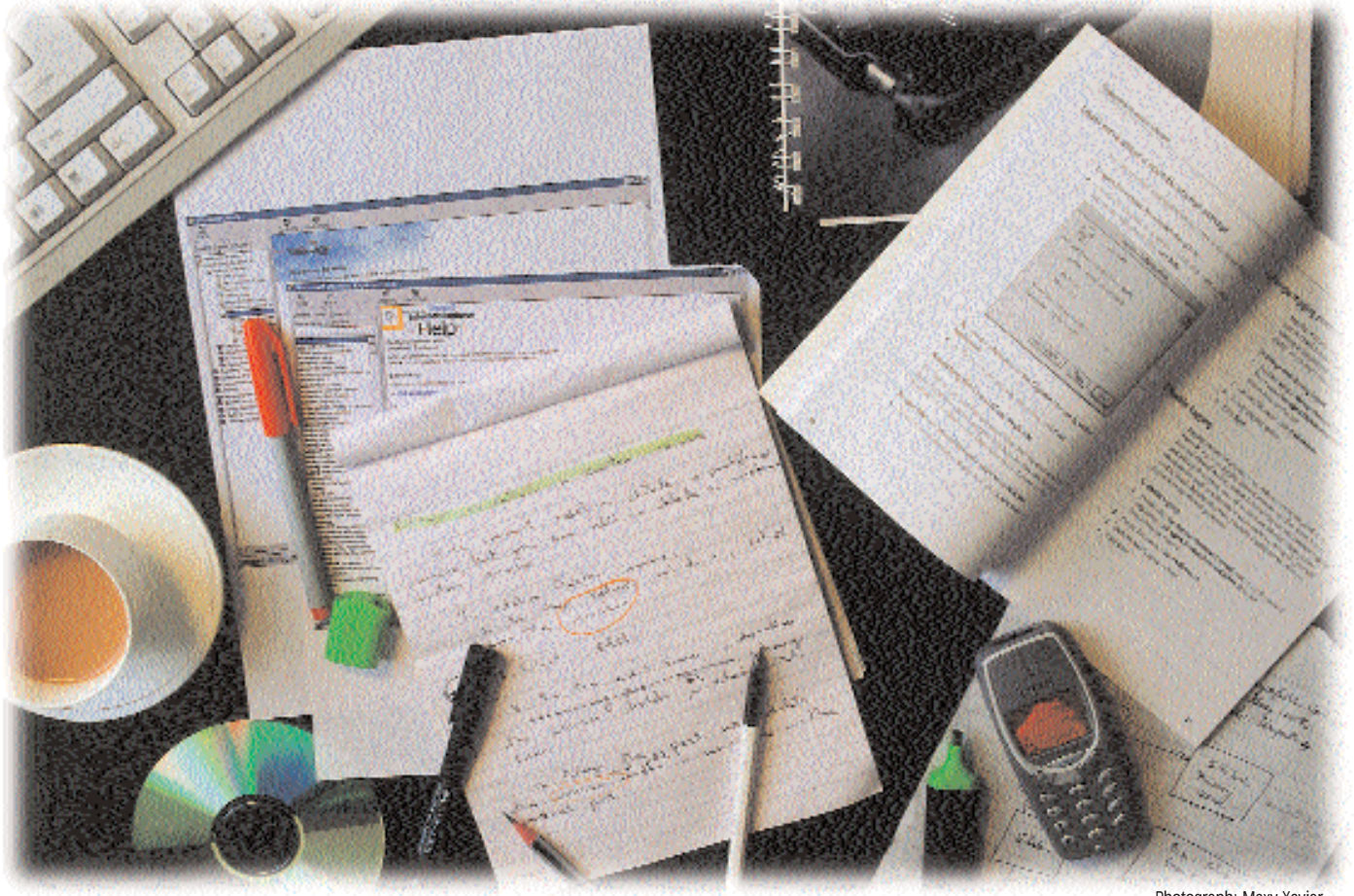


A write job for techies



Photograph: Mexy Xavier

What can be the perfect job for a person who loves technology, and writing even more?

Clue: It's not a rocket scientist

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Do your skill sets lie in explaining how to best utilise technology? Do spelling and grammatical mistakes stare out at you from a page, begging to be corrected? Do your friends know you as the 'communicator'? Do you have that special knack for everything technology, but still hate the routine that the job involves? If your answers are mostly yes, then you should perhaps evaluate the option of becoming a technical writer.

The general opinion of writing as a means of livelihood is that it simply doesn't pay enough. Well, it's not so with technical writing. It pays, and it pays well. If you love technology and can express yourself well, this could be the next dream job you were waiting for.

What is technical writing?

All of us are familiar with the information manuals that come with appliances like TVs, computers, etc. Most of us use Help files in software programs such as Word or Windows. Ever

wondered who makes these manuals and help files? All this is the work of the behind-the-scene wizard, better known as a technical writer.

The first question that comes to you might be this: Is a technical writer the engineer who designs the technology and one who knows everything about it? The answer is no. A technical writer is a specialist in documentation work and is highly skilled in all areas of document design and publication. He is not a geek and he need not be an engineer. What he does best is simplify and explain technology to the end users and target audiences.

At best, a technical writer can be defined as someone who teaches complex ideas to others using the written word. Sajitha Jayaprakash, a technical writer working with Fluent India, has this perception: "A technical writer compiles information of a technical nature and puts it in a language and format that can be easily understood by the readers who are unfamiliar with that technology".

The most imperative thing for any technical